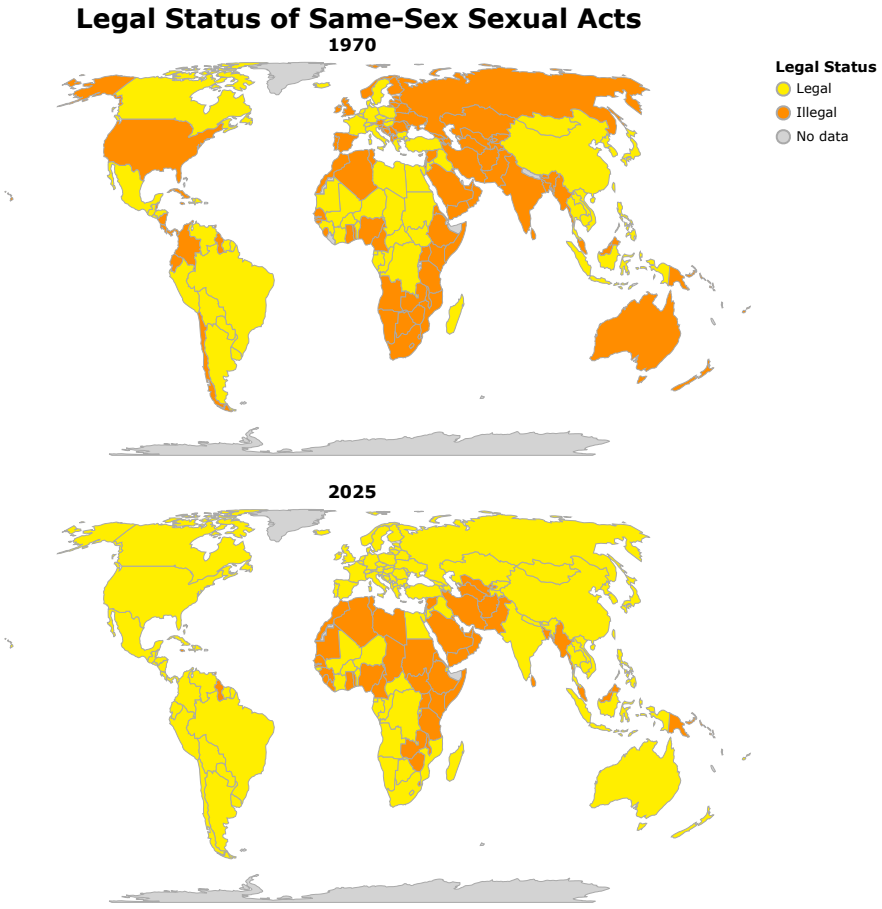
The Lasting Impact of Colonization on LGBT+ Rights

In pre-colonial Nigeria, the Igbo and Yoruba tribes didn't adhere to a binary gender system and opted to assign genders later in life, rather than a birth. In Igboland, you might find a woman who had married another woman, taking on the role of a "female husband" (The impact of colonial legacies, 2023). This reality changed with the colonization of Nigeria by Britain.



Many countries in Africa gained independence by the 1970s, but many restrictions on LGBT+ people still exist (and have been introduced) since then.

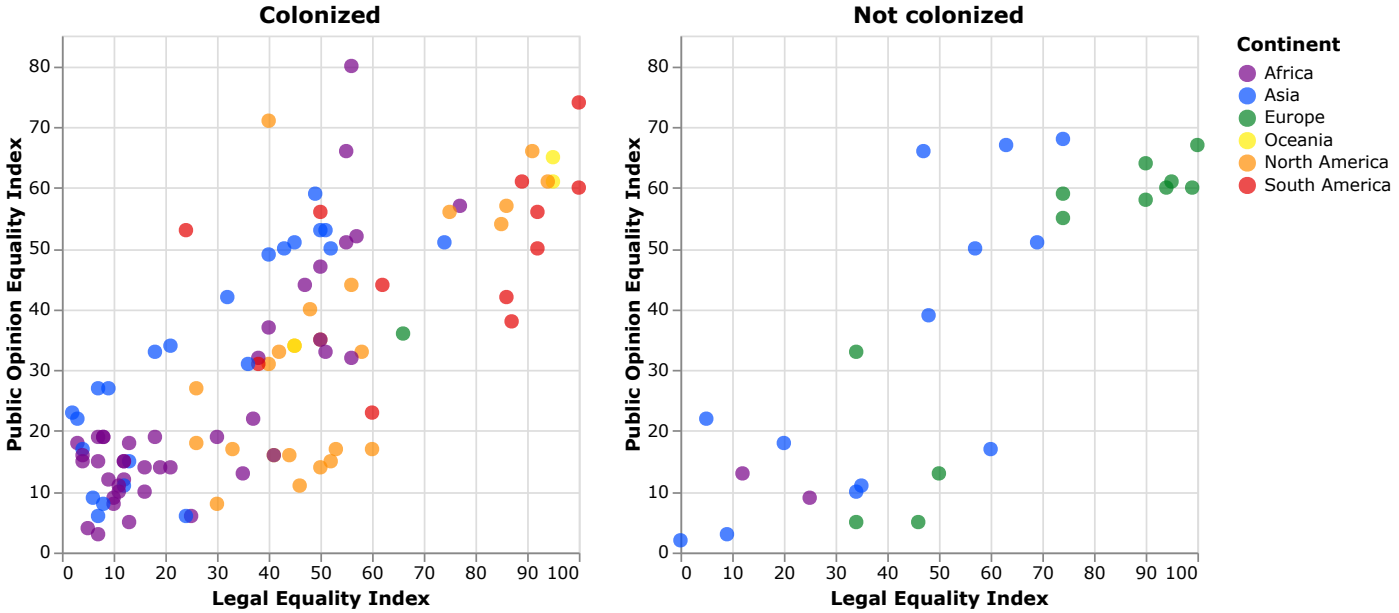
In 1533, King Henry VIII passed the Buggery Act, making sexual relations between men punishable by death. Versions of this law remained in place in the United Kingdom until 1967, and were imposed upon other parts of the world through Britain's colonial conquests (Rainbow Railroad, 2026). Britain colonized Nigeria in the 19th century, and later introduced the CriminalCode Act of 1916 that criminalized same-sex intimacy.

With the introduction of British ideals, practices that were once fluid, locally negotiated, or tied to specific kinship and spiritual systems were reclassified as "unnatural" or "un-African," laying the groundwork for modern criminalization laws like post-independence statutes. More recently in Nigeria, the Criminal Code Act 40 criminalizes consensual same-sex sexual acts with a penalty of imprisonment for 14 years (The impact of colonial legacies, 2023).

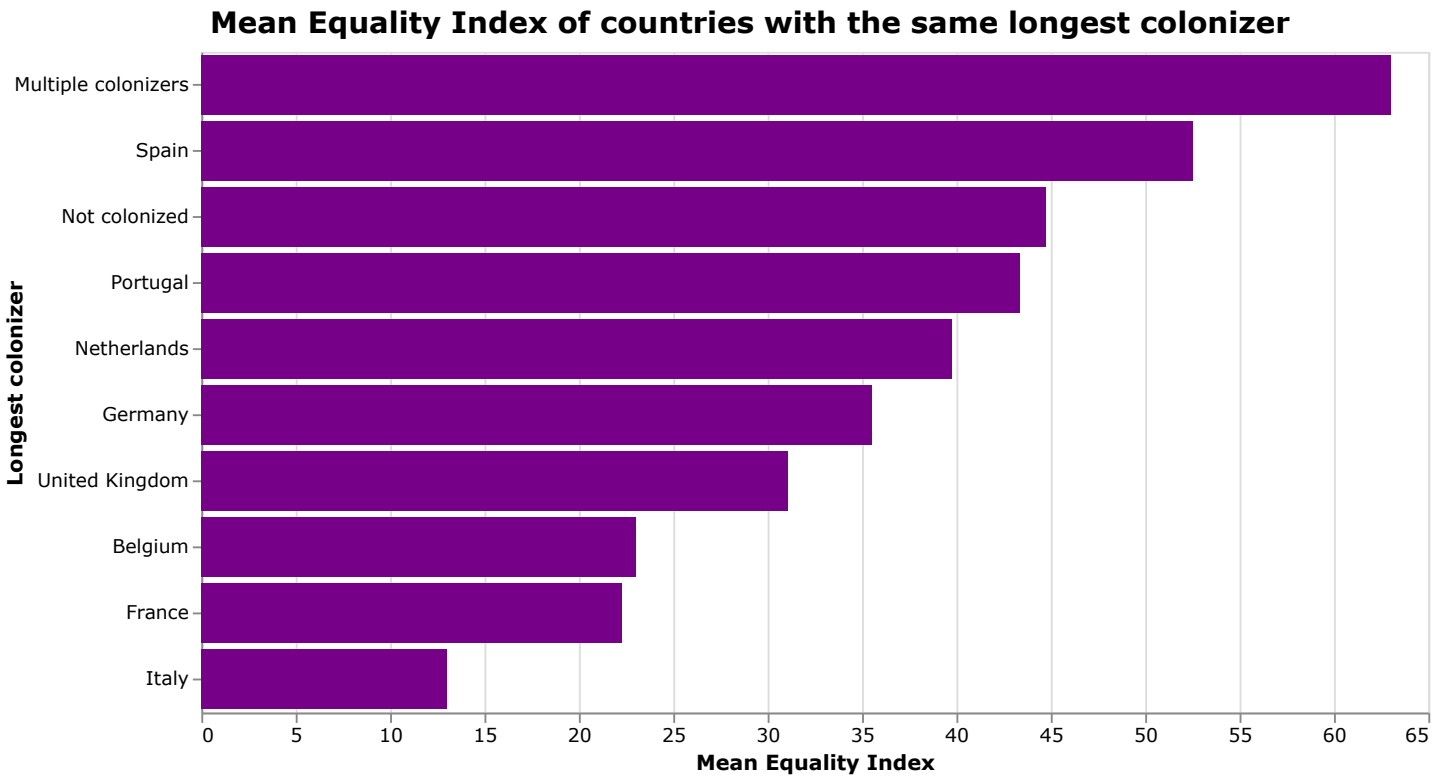
Similar histories of colonial-driven penal codes and laws inspired by European culture and religion – spread by countries such as France and Spain – have had a lasting impact on the rights and protections of LGBT+ people across the world. The lasting impact of these laws is that not only are same-sex relations illegal in many African countries – they are often criminalized.

What is the Equality Index?

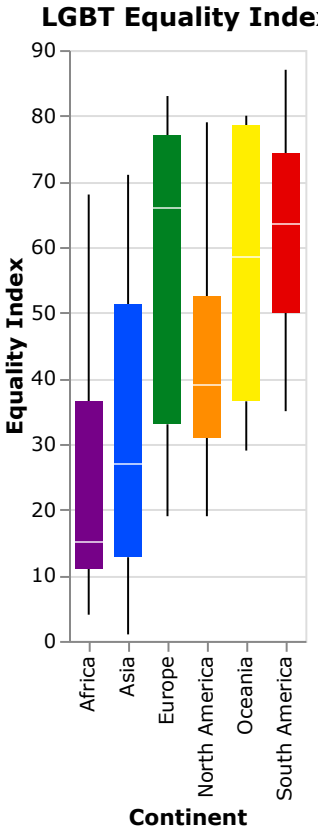
The Equaldex Equality Index (EI) is a measure of the current status of LGBT rights, laws, freedoms, and public attitudes towards LGBT people. The index takes into account laws and public opinion regarding gay marriage, censorship, gender-affirming care, hate crime protections, same-sex adoption, etc. The index is on a scale of 0 to 100, where 0 = less equal to cisgender, heterosexual people and 100 = more equal to cisgender, heterosexual people.

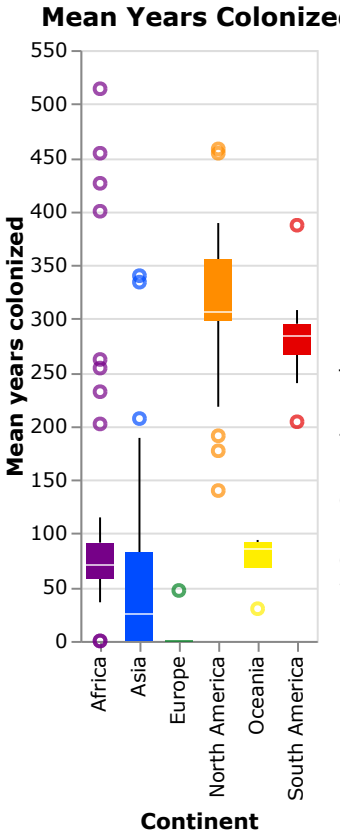


Every African country, aside from South Africa, has a legal EI below 60 – even those that have not been colonized (Ethiopia and Liberia).



The UK and France colonized much of Africa, and the mean equality index of their previous colonies is among the lowest of the colonizers.









The prevalence of a lack of LGBT rights and protections in Africa does not seem to be related to length of colonization, seeing as the mean for years colonized is relatively low compared to other continents. Rather, this trend may be due to the lasting impacts of colonization coupled with recent and present-day exploitation that continue the proliferation of a historically archaic European "morality". This allows central European countries to portray themselves as progressive, while the places that they colonized still grapple with the effects of Europe's past regressiveness.

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